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Culture (OWC): [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)

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Place Coverage

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Section Title(S): CLITORIDECTOMY • SECLUSION

A female circumciser does not work in the open under a tree like her male counterpart, but under the eaves of her own hut. The girl sits on a manger (*orotuba*) – this consists of a hollowed-out log – and is supported from behind by an older girl, in much the same attitude as the Gusii use for non-ritual surgical operations. Her back rests against the supporter's breast and her face is turned towards the supporter's armpit. However, a girl who flinches ranks as an *enkuri*, like a boy, and is treated in the same way. She has 'spoilt the manger' as he has 'spoilt the tree'. Her mother and an old woman relative must fetch her home when a goat or sheep has been paid for redemption, and the operation is done in private.

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The Gusii say that their own mode of clitoridectomy is less painful than that of the Kipsigis, Tende, and other peoples known to them.¹ They also claim that the greater skill of their circumcisers adds to the speed and reduces the pain of the operation. The circumciser has a basketful of flour, with which she first smears the clitoris to make it 'strong', that is, easier to grasp. Having removed the clitoris by means of a knife, she breaks out into a trill as a signal that the operation is successfully over. As she raises the hand that holds the knife, the women and girls join in the trilling, while the novice is led aside and given a bunch of *ekerundu* grass like a boy after his circumcision.

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When the whole team of girls has been operated on, the circumciser leads off the singing of the *esimbore* song. The girl escorts take up the song and continue it on the homeward journey:

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Goko² okorie buya. [*Refrain*] Aye, oye. Abarate ekeita. Orenge moka baisia, Obeire moka bamura. Igesora na igesora, Totegorere amaboga.³

Simbore aito yarure rogoro. Nyambegeera, moka Asago, Oirire ebisono
biaito Ochire kokekera!

Interlinear
Translations

Granny has done well.
[Refrain] Aye, oye.
She is going to pass through the cattle-pen.
She was a wife for uninitiated boys,
Now she is a wife for initiated youths.
After harvest, after harvest,
We shall cultivate our second crops.
Our esimbore song has come from up yonder.
Nyambegeera, wife of Asago,
Has taken our clitoris
And has gone to dry it!

When the novice has been returned to her homestead, where trills and praise-songs greet her, she is left to rest behind her mother's hut and not under the granaries as a boy is. It is in the living-room of the mother's hut that she will be secluded, and there the ritual fire is kindled. This is the first of the occasions on which boys intervene in the initiation rites of girls. Two initiated youths (*abamura*) have to be called to make the fire, in the same way as it is made for a boy novice. Any fire already in the hut is removed, and the mother will continue her cooking over the ritual fire.

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Fire

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SECLUSION

The leading of a girl into seclusion follows the same broad pattern as that in the case of a boy, but some extra episodes are interpolated. In these episodes mature women take part. Their action consists in formalized attacks on and insults directed against the novice's mother. However, ¹28 these are playful or joking insults: the tone is of high good humour. The performances make the entry of a girl into seclusion far more entertaining than the entry of a boy.

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¹The following extract from a letter written by the Medical Officer-in-Charge, Native Hospital, Kisii, dated 26 October 1944 (Southern Nyanza District File ADM. 15/16/1) is relevant here: 'They [the Gusii] remove head of clitoris only, leaving no scar, and not interfering with vaginal orifice', though the operation among the Tende is 'more extensive'.

²*Goko* (granny) is commonly used as a term of endearment or flattery to small girls.

³*Amaboba* are secondary crops of maize and beans sown among the stubble after the main eleusine crop has been harvested.

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